

## **Prompt: Tell me about the digital divide**

The **digital divide** refers to the gap between those who have meaningful access to digital technology (internet, devices, digital literacy) and those who don't.

### **Key dimensions:**

- **Access** – physical availability of devices and broadband infrastructure
- **Affordability** – cost of devices and connectivity
- **Digital literacy** – skills to use technology effectively
- **Quality of use** – difference between passive consumption and productive use

### **Who it affects most:**

- Rural and remote communities
- Low-income households
- Older adults
- Developing nations
- People with disabilities

**Why it matters:** The divide compounds inequality — those without access are excluded from online education, remote work, telehealth, e-government services, and economic opportunity. It's not just about internet access but about who can fully participate in modern society.

**Current state (2024–2026):** Despite progress, roughly 2.6 billion people globally remain offline. In developed countries like the UK, gaps persist along income and age lines even where infrastructure exists — "digital inclusion" has become a policy priority distinct from mere connectivity.

**Interventions** typically target infrastructure investment (e.g., rural broadband rollout), subsidised devices/data, and community digital literacy programmes.

## **Prompt: Explain the causes and effects of the digital divide in the UK**

Claude responded:

### **Causes**

- **Affordability** — the lack of access to affordable, reliable internet remains a significant barrier, compounded by device and data costs. Digital exclusion creates

a "poverty premium" where those offline pay more for services in non-digital ways. PurplePurple

- **Age & skills** — 77% of those with no basic digital skills are over 65. Rsonline
- **Disability** — 69% of digitally excluded people have a disability. Rsonline
- **Education & employment** — 31% of unemployed people have low or very low digital capability, compared to 19% of the employed. The British Academy
- **Geography** — rural areas face poor infrastructure, and rural communities may be disproportionately impacted due to older local populations. Rsonline
- **Lack of qualifications** — 47% of those without formal qualifications are digitally excluded. Rsonline

### Effects

- **Health** — difficulties booking appointments, accessing telehealth, and obtaining health information disproportionately harm the digitally excluded. The Lancet
- **Mental health & isolation** — lack of digital access has consequences for wellbeing and mental health, since being able to connect with other people is critical. The Lancet
- **Education** — digital poverty poses a significant threat to higher education's core principles of accessibility and equity, and without intervention the gap between digitally privileged and disadvantaged students will widen. Springer
- **Economic** — digital exclusion impacts all aspects of people's lives, creating financial, social, and health problems and costing the UK economy billions in missed opportunities. Conversely, for every £1 invested in digital skills training, approximately £9.48 is generated in the UK economy. PurplePurple
- **Social exclusion** — research shows a clear correlation between digital and social exclusion, reinforcing existing inequalities. RGS

**Prompt: Explain the causes and effects of the digital divide in the UK in a manner suitable for an older child.**

Claude responded:

The digital divide is about the gap between people who can use the internet and technology easily, and those who can't. Here's why it happens and what it means for people in the UK:

**Why does it happen? (Causes)**

- **Money** — Phones, computers, and paying for internet access all cost money. Families who can't afford these things get left behind.
- **Where you live** — People in rural areas (countryside villages) often can't get fast broadband because the cables and equipment haven't been installed there.
- **Age** — Many older people grew up before the internet existed, so they never learned how to use it confidently.
- **Disability** — Some disabilities make it harder to use devices, and not all technology is designed with this in mind.
- **Education** — People who left school without many qualifications are less likely to have learned digital skills.

### What does it mean for people? (Effects)

- **Health** — If you can't get online, booking a GP appointment or getting health advice is much harder, especially as the NHS moves more services online.
- **Loneliness** — A lot of social life — keeping in touch with friends and family — happens online. Being cut off can make people feel isolated.
- **Education** — Students without home internet or a device struggle with homework, online learning, and job applications.
- **Money problems** — Many cheaper deals (energy, banking, shopping) are only available online. People without internet access end up paying more for the same things.
- **Jobs** — Most job applications are online. Without digital skills, it's much harder to find work.

The key point is that missing out on the internet doesn't just mean missing out on Netflix — it makes almost every part of life harder, and tends to make existing inequalities worse.

**Prompt: You are a PHSE (Personal, Social, Health and Economic Education) teacher in an English secondary school. In 400 to 500 words, discuss the social and economic causes and effects of the digital divide in language suitable for 12 and 13-year-olds in a mainstream urban secondary school. Give three points each for causes and effects, and ensure the language is age-appropriate for the audience.**

Claude responded:

## The Digital Divide: Who Gets Left Behind and Why?

Imagine trying to do your homework without the internet, or your parents not being able to apply for a job online. For millions of people across the UK, this is everyday life. This gap between people who can use technology confidently and those who can't is called the **digital divide** — and it affects real people in real ways.

### What Causes the Digital Divide?

**1. Money and poverty** The most obvious reason is cost. A decent laptop can cost hundreds of pounds, and home broadband adds another £30–£50 a month. For families already struggling to pay rent or buy food, technology simply isn't a priority. This means children in lower-income households are much less likely to have their own device or reliable internet at home.

**2. Where people live** Not everywhere in the UK has fast, reliable internet. Rural villages and some urban areas — including parts of cities like Manchester, Birmingham, and London — still have poor connectivity. Even if a family can afford broadband, they might not be able to get a decent connection where they live, putting them at an immediate disadvantage.

**3. Skills and confidence** Access isn't just about having a device — it's about knowing how to use it. Many older adults grew up long before smartphones existed and never had the chance to build digital skills. Without support or training, technology can feel confusing and even frightening, so some people simply avoid it altogether.

### What Are the Effects?

**1. Falling behind at school and work** During COVID-19 lockdowns, millions of pupils across the UK had no device or internet at home when schools closed. Those students fell significantly behind their peers. The same happens with jobs — most applications, training courses, and even workplace communication now happen online. Without digital skills, young people and adults find it much harder to compete.

**2. Paying more for everyday things** This one might surprise you: being offline actually costs more money. The best deals on energy bills, insurance, and shopping are almost always found online. People without internet access miss out on these savings and end up paying higher prices — a problem sometimes called the **poverty premium**. It's a vicious cycle: being poor makes it harder to get online, and being offline makes it harder to escape poverty.

**3. Loneliness and being cut off** So much of modern social life happens online — group chats, social media, video calls with family. People who can't participate in this can feel isolated and left out of their communities. For elderly people especially, this can seriously affect their mental health and wellbeing.

### **So What?**

The digital divide isn't just a technology problem — it's a **fairness problem**. Until everyone has equal access to the internet and the skills to use it, some people will always be at a disadvantage through no fault of their own.